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Multi-centric Mythscapes : Sanctuaries and Pilgrimages in Northwest Amazon Arawakan Religious Traditions

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Abstract

In this study, we discuss the narrative traditions of indigenous South American peoples, especially the Northern Arawak-speaking peoples of Northwest Amazonia, and the themes of pilgrimage and sanctuary, which are understood through the notion of multi-centered mythscapes. Each of the numerous northern

Arawak-speaking peoples developed traditions of sacred geographies related to their principal creation narratives, emergence and processions of primordial ancestors, migrations of historical ancestors, and places of shamanic protection. In this study, we discuss three such multi-centered mythscapes remembered by the Hohodene of the Aiary River, the Koripako of the upper Içana, the Baniva and Warekena of the upper Guainia and caño San Miguel. Underlying these traditions are stories of diaspora and exile, healing and revival, centrifugal and centripetal[1]movements, and the consecration of places where protection by the deities and the souls of powerful shamanic seers can be obtained. Each of the sacred 'centers' and spirit-entities to which they refer are marked by ambiguity in combining within themselves the primordium, the present, and future; mixing, opposing, or juxtaposing the primordial spirit entities with the material world, the powers of sorcery and harmonious conviviality, the continuity of kinship bonds with the potential treachery in affinal relations.

Introduction

The region of the Northwest Amazon (see map, p. 5 below) is known for both its social and linguistic heterogeneity and yet, to a high degree, its cultural homogeneity. The more than 22 ethnic groups who consider themselves as distinct socio-political units are grouped by linguists into three major language families: northern Arawak, eastern Tukano, and Maku.. Despite their linguistic diversity, all peoples share in a number of cultural patterns and institutions, among them the sacred rites of passage involving a set of ancestral flutes and trumpets which are

considered to be the Body of the first ancestral being from which came the ancestors of all peoples. At the present time, some of the indigenous religious traditions are undergoing a period of revitalization and re-membering, after a long period of repression by missionaries and forgetting of the rituals. In the not-too-distant past, the knowledge of the rituals was guarded mostly by the healer pajés (shamans) and the priestly elders. [2]

This study is concerned with the northern Arawakan-speaking peoples (sometimes called Maipurean languages) which, today, inhabit the upper Guainia River and its tributaries, the Içana River and its tributaries, in the frontier region of Brazil, Venezuela, and Colombia. Specifically, we focus on the Hohodene, a large sib of the Baniwa which inhabits the Aiary River in Brazil; the Kuripako, an ethno-linguistic group consisting of multiple sibs on the upper Içana River in Brazil and Colombia; and the Warekena and Baniva of the upper Guainia and Cassiquiare Rivers in Venezuela. Research has been conducted by Wright since the mid-1970s; Gonzalez-Ñáñez, since the late 1960s/early 1970s; and Xavier Leal, in the first decade of the present century. [3]

The term 'pilgrimage' refers to a journey, especially a long one, made to some sacred place as an act of religious devotion; the term 'sanctuary' is understood as a place where someone or something is protected or given shelter. As these terms apply to the traditions of Northern Arawak-speaking peoples, there are numerous, interconnected sacred places where events of major importance to the creation of the world are marked, often by petroglyphs, or meaningful arrangements of boulders. Sacred narratives recount that in primordial times, the

creators of the world made long journeys, or processions, beginning and/or ending at these sacred places during the course of which they celebrated the first rituals of initiation. These journeys are recalled in minute detail by elderly chanters who re-member them in a lengthy series of chants performed in the course of these rites today. [4]

The creation stories of northern Arawak-speaking peoples are marked by multiple 'centers' at which major transformational events occurred in primordial times (the first birth, the first death, the first initiation rite, emergence of the first ancestors). These centers are described in minute detail by the elders, the jaguar shamans, seers and savants, who – based on their direct experiences of the sacred – are capable of explaining holistically every shape and form, inscription, locations, and inter-relations among elements of these sites. The 'centers' are also 'sanctuaries' in the sense that they are highly-charged sources of cosmic life-force protected by the specialists; their sacredness involves both a deep respect for their intrinsic significance, a strong tabu (enforced by sorcery) against disturbing any aspect or feature in them, and their connection with the invisible (except to the specialists), other world of the spirits and creator deities. Each center is understood to be a unique portal to the sacred.

Map 1: Mythscapes of the Northwest Amazon

[INSERT MAP 1]

Sacred Mythscapes

Each ethno-linguistic group has/had its own sacred mythscape. These mythscapes were both 'multi-centric' (having one or more sacred centers where life-defining transformations occurred) with the capacity to expand centrifugally outwards to the furthest reaches of the known world and contract centripetally back inward. Expansive phases refer to the primordial 'opening up' of the world, which can have many meanings, such as historical exile from the world-center to the extreme peripheries (the boundaries with alterity) followed by a return home and regaining of power.

The idea of a multi-centered world resolves an apparent ambiguity of a world that was created at various points in space and through distinct world-opening acts. Although all peoples recognize the center of the universe, where the universe began, as the place called *Hipana* on the Aiary River, each phratry has relations with the sacred spaces in its own territory that replicate all others. Near

the headwaters of the Içana River, for example, the Koripako people also refer to a rapids called *Hipana* where, they say, there are "holes at the bottom" and the dwelling-places of the *Yoopinai* spirits. They say there could be a direct connection (underground) with the rapids of *Hipana,* on the Aiary River, the place of origin of the universe for all northern Arawak-speaking peoples. For the Koripako, the place is (or was, since most are now evangelical) an important place of Animal Souls, a sacred place or *yaradathi.*

In both cases, *Hipana* is the name for a sacred center and not a village settlement. There are other such names for sacred centers: *Kaali ka thadapani* [Great House/ Tree of Sustenance], *Warukwa* [place of the Creator], *Ehnipan* [place of the first Initiation], *Enúkwa* [place of ancestral emergence], and *Motípana* [House of the first women] each referring to points on a 'map' of the primordial world where there are extensive petroglyphs, or rock formations, and other outstanding geographical features that are connected to the narratives of creation.

Not all of these 'centers' have the same importance nor qualities. *Ehnípan* , (or Jandú Rapids on the Içana River downriver from *Hipana* of the Aiary), is a center unto itself and yet, at the same time, a complement to the great world-center on the Aiary River, since it is the origin place of the most important rite of initiation, when the world "expanded" and "contracted" with the sounds of the great spirit *Kuwai* whose body became the sacred flutes and trumpets; and the place where he "died", that is, left this world for the Other World of the ancestors.

While the sacred centers of the world, the sanctuaries, and the ancestral emergence places of northern Arawak-speakers are the sources of new life,

ambiguity is a feature that permeates their powers, insofar as they are also sources of primordial poison and sorcery. To visit any one of these places today, one must treat them with great respect, as places that "have their own time" (Vine DeLoria, n.d.), where the power of the sacred events that took place there (and are often seen in every detail of these spaces) is still present and vibrant. The power of creation is inextricably tied to the power of destruction, as healing and sorcery, life and death, are two sides of the same entity. This is a common theme in the sacred stories of the northern Arawak-speaking peoples (Baniwa, Kuripako, Warekena, and others), but it is especially evident in the sacred story of how the world came into being and was reproduced for all times, the story of *Kuwai* (see below).

The idea of a multi-centric world is also consistent with the disputes told in narratives between the phratries, clans, and ethnic groups. We include in this article a brief consideration of narratives of the historical ancestors, along with certain healing chants, insofar as they recall processes of forced exile to peripheral lands and return to the homelands, the center of the world. Shamanic healing itself is largely focused on the epidemics and sicknesses that come from the external world and healing or protection by returning to the world center. The great shaman seers of the historic past created such sanctuaries or reinforced pre-existing ones.

In most cases, the world of alterity (the "others", non-kin, affines or enemies) surrounds the world of "people" (all those considered kin, and who speak northern Arawak languages). Ambiguity inheres in the relation between kin (inside, at the center) and non-kin (others, on the peripheries). In order for there

to be continuity of the internal world of kin, there must exist the hostility of the external enemy, whose powers are nevertheless considered necessary for the reproduction of the internal world of kin.

Representations And Interconnections

Considered altogether, the graphic representations of the primordial beings, petroglyphs chiseled in the distant past into the boulders of many rapids in the Northwest Amazon, constitute a cultural memory of the primordial worlds, how they came into being, and the world-changing events that made the contemporary world the way it is. (Wright, 2013; Gonzalez-Ñánez, 1980; Xavier Leal, 2013)[5] This cultural memory can be understood as a social history as well, in the most essential meaning of the term, as a view of how society is reproduced over time (Turner, in Hill, 1988). For, the elements comprising the sacred mythscape orient the peoples today as to the spirit-powers that brought the world into existence, threatened it with destruction, or guaranteed its continuity over time.

Among northern Arawak-speaking peoples, furthermore, there is a strong belief in the association of primordial shamans and spirits with material places (large boulders in the rivers, caves, hills, depressions in the rocks of the rivers) in this world. Thus, there are numerous 'stone-houses' situated throughout each phratry's territory that are places of the "First Fruits" and their spirit-owner, the *Yoopinai* spirits, the mountaintop sources of all fish, and so forth. Several of these

places require appropriate behavior when they are approached, such as silence, avoidance of looks so as not to attract or disturb those spirits because they may give humans sickness.[6] Others are 'stone-houses' associated with primordial shamans, where people can solicit their protection from sickness or misfortune.

The different senses of connectedness amongst sacred sites in the Northwest Amazon include: (1) through the petroglyphs illustrating fundamental themes of sustenance, birth, emergence and creation, initiation, death, and the spirit-world; (2) various kinds of movement in primordial time and space, of expansion outward and contraction inward, exemplified particularly in the voyages of the primordial women when they had sacred instruments in their power, and made the entire world a fertile space; (3)the narratives of exile and return of the historical ancestors from their homelands; and (4) places to which people today journey in order to leave offerings to the souls of past great shamans and wise people.

Thus, the site called *Kaali ka thadapani* (Uaracapury, on the upper Uaupés River) is where the 'Great Tree of Sustenance', the 'House of the Earth-Master *Kaali*,' once stood. This 'House' existed in the miniature world prior to the birth of *Kuwai*. Then, there is the site called *Hipana*, where *Kuwai* was born and the first ancestors came out of the holes of the stone earth. Several other sites mark places of the Creator's houses and world-transforming events. One of these 'houses of the Creator' is where death came into the world. All but the last of these places are marked by numerous petroglyphs, traces or reminders of primordial acts, beings, and events; some even have apparently cosmologically significant arrangements of

boulders . Altogether, the model of a sacred 'mythscape' can be represented in the form of a quadrangle with a hole in the center. Such a form delimits the universe for each northern Arawak-speaking society in the region.

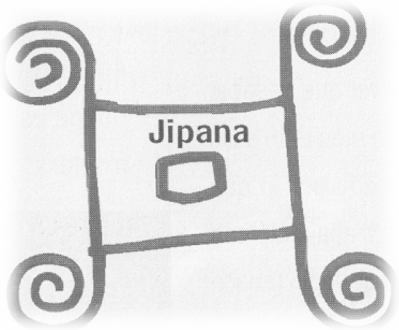


Fig. 1: The Center (Kúwai) and Four Directions where Sky and Earth Meet (Tsúwai) according to northern Arawak of the Northwest Amazon

(petroglyph located at Jurupary Falls, *Inyaipana*)

Comparing amongst the diverse mythscapes of the Arawak-speaking peoples in the Northwest Amazon Region, there are important concordances but also divergences. This can readily be seen in the chanting traditions called *kalidzamai (*for the Warekena: *Kalidama;* for the Baré, *Kariamã*), that recount the journeys of the primordial men and women to the ends of the world and back at the time of the first initiation rites (see Vidal, 2000, 1987, for example). These chants are of particular significance to the interconnectedness among sacred spaces as frameworks within which all sacred sites are interconnected, expanding

outward to the limits of the world, contracting inward to the universe-center, and connecting the upper layers of the cosmos with this world.

Among the Piapoco, the Warekena, Dzauinai, Hohodene, and probably many other peoples, these chants are known as the "Voyages of *Kuwai*", child of the Creator and First Woman (Vidal, 2000, 1987; González-Ñáñez, 1987; Hill, 1993; Wright, 1993). Among the Hohodene (Baniwa of the Aiary River), these complex chants invoke the *Ipanai*, the House-spirits visited during a series of primordial processions made by the first women as they blew the sacred trumpets and flutes – the transformed body of their son, *Kuwai*. In doing so, they left the ancestral spirits of *Kuwai (Kuwainai*) music in every place of importance in the world. These voyages are conceptualized as a "pursuit" by the Creator to regain the flutes (Wright, 1993), which the women had stolen from the men. At the end of these journeys, the chanters then "bring back tobacco to the Center of the World, *Hipana*". This return journey concentrates the spiritual power that filled the world with its sounds and sends it back upwards to the center of the sky. Once the flutes were regained, the Creator sent the women on a "mission" to the ends of the world (more exactly, to the four "skies" – east, west, south, north) where they became the "Mothers of the Whites".

Whether "pursuit" or "mission", we see these world-expanding processions by and with the flutes as "pilgrimages" since, during them, the music of the sacred imbued the world with its power, and continues to do so every time an initiation rite is performed and the chants remembering the voyages are sung by the elders. These elderly, priestly chanters embody the primordial chanters, journeying in

their thought, and with tobacco smoke, along the same routes as the first voyages. The task of the chanters is extensive and must be done in an exact order; otherwise, their purpose – to protect the newly initiated boys and girls from potential harm that spirits anywhere in the known world could do to them – will not be fulfilled.

The First World

From the perspective of the Arawak-speaking peoples of the Aiary River (primarily Hohodene), the very first world was a ball of stone floating in empty space. The very first being, "Universe Child", separated a piece of this stone ball and made it rise up in the sky to become the primordial sun, leaving behind a "pot"(circular depression) in the stone ball. Shortly after, he went to look for the very first ancestors who emerged from the open hole left by the sun, at the place called *Hipana,* the "Universe Navel", the "Celestial Umbilicus" connecting the sky with the earth. As the first ancestors emerged from the hole, each singing its own song, the Creator sent them to their lands. At that time, there were no rivers, no riverbeds, no food for the first living beings.



Fig. 2 (Photo: M.C. Wright, 2009) **The great boulder** (lower left) **is the first earth** which floated in infinite space, before there was any water flowing at the rapids; in the center of the narrow passage is a perfectly round and deep depression in the rocks which is said to be where the first ancestors emerged.

At another center-place, in the worlds that pre-existed the present earth, there was the primordial Tree of Sustenance which contained all the original plant-foods and fruits, as well as the original shamanic powers, including pariká beans. The Creator and his people obtained these shamanic powers by cutting down this Tree, called *Kaali ka Thadapani*, "House of the Earth-Master". The felling of the great tree opened up connections amongst all the communities of the world at that time, each of which could then obtain their shares of food to plant. Those connections became the five principal riverbeds of the Northwest Amazon; all of

the riverbeds would, at a later moment, be filled by the fertile blood of the First Woman. The felling of the Tree brought all food and shamanic powers into the world; the latter, however, were "stolen" by the tapir, creating a situation of chaos that the Creator had to set right by reclaiming ownership of them. This was the beginning of shamanic powers to heal; but it was also the beginning of the forest-spirits into which Tapir's companions, crazed by their inhaling of the sacred snuff, transformed.

In the drawing below, the each fallen tree becomes a riverbed:



Fig. 3. Opening Of The Riverbeds Of The Northwest Amazon (which would later be filled by the rivers of blood from First Woman)

(drawing by Thiago Aguilar, Uapui, 2010)

The Creator *Nhiaperíkuli* (spelled in various ways: *Naperúli*, *Iñiãperikuli*, *Ñaperikoli)*, according to the traditions of various northern Arawak-speaking

peoples, lived in the primordial times, in several different places of what is now known as the Northwest Amazon region. For the Hohodene peoples, there is an island called *Warukwa* (see drawing below) on the *Dzukuali* river, a short distance from *Hipana*, where *Nhiaperikuli* had a house. There, according to the stories, *Nhiaperikuli* and his brothers had many adventures with the fish-peoples, the great Anaconda, and others, but most importantly, from there he shamanically fertilized with coca and incantations, the First Woman with the child *Kuwai.*



Fig. 4: *Warukwa*, *Nhiaperikuli*'s House On The *Dzukuali* River, Upper Aiary. (Here, the Creator performed shamanism over the fish)

Sacred Powers of The Center of the Universe

Hipana is considered the center of the universe in both a vertical and a horizontal sense. This most important place situated on the Aiary River (at the rapids also known as *Kupí*) was where *Kuwai,* the child of the Creator (*Nhiaperikuli*) and the First Woman (*Amaru*), was born. The boulders and petroglyphs there illustrate the following elements representing *Kuwai's* birth: a line of boulders mark where *Amaru* 'sat' before she gave birth to *Kuwai*, and where girls at their menarche sit today so that their bodies may become strong; a boulder with designs of the Pleiades constellation, the time of plant growth, and others associated with *Amaru*; a boulder that represents "*Kuwai*", with petroglyphs of a serpent representing the "pain of the whip",[7] and spirals that are the "sounds of the flutes"; another boulder, a short distance away, is said to represent the "true *Kuwai*"; a stone that has the shape of the "placenta of *Kuwai"* after he was born, in the shape of a freshwater stingray; several boulders representing the sacred flutes of *Kuwai*, and hawk feathers that empowered the original flutes to open the "voice of *Kuwai"*; a place of the ancient village where *Nhiaperikuli* made the *Kuwai* flutes. (Gonzalez-Nanez, 1987)

Besides these, the sacred place of *Hipana* is 'announced' to anyone approaching it from downstream by a large petroglyph of *Kuwai* on the face of one of the main boulders at the mouth of this portal to the sacred. In the reproduction below, a drawing of *Kuwai* by a shaman's apprentice and artist is juxtaposed with this petroglyph; the body of this spirit of sickness and sorcery, its 'shadow-soul' (*idanami*) is that of a sloth mixed with the teeth of a jaguar, and the face of a White Man. *Kuwai* was, after all, a univocal combination of alterity and identity,

exceedingly dangerous to humans. The petroglyph, on the other hand, shows parts of *Kuwai*'s segmented body along with rounded and swirl shapes that are the musical sounds emitted from his body.

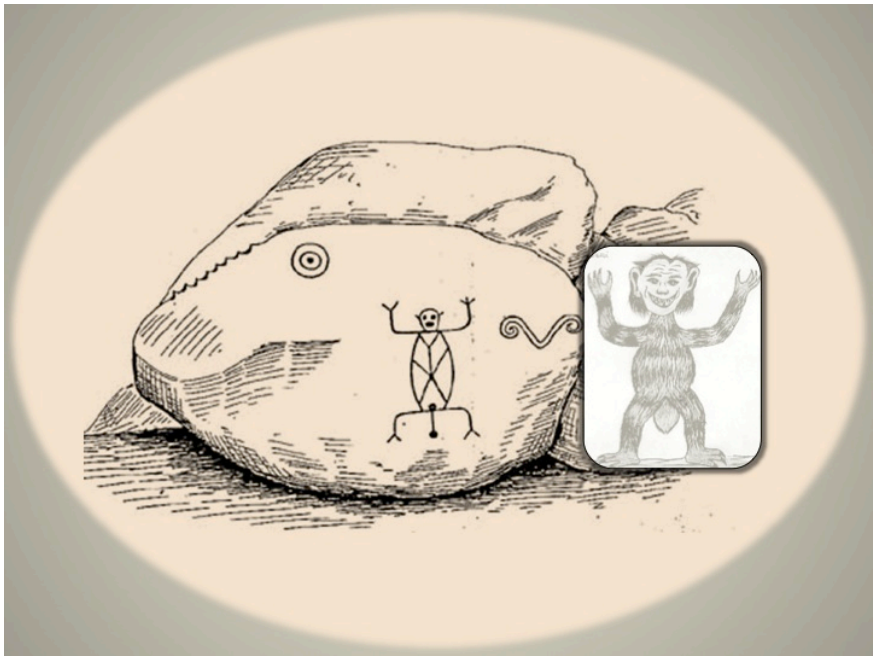


Fig. 5: Petroglyph and Drawing of *Kuwai-ka-Wamundana* (drawing by T. Aguilar, 2010)

Kuwai's sounds and singing created the world, that is, made it open up (expand) from its primordial, miniature size, to the huge territory and world that the Baniwa know today.

The First Woman Looks For A Center To Give Birth

According to one version of *Kuwai*'s birth:

"Before *Kuwai* was born, his mother *Amaru* went looking for a place to give birth . She went to the Uaupés River, later the Içana River – at the place called *Tsépan* – and she lay down there. Later, she went to

Puwedali, on the *Ucaiali* (Uaupés) River, and went to lie down there.. Later, *Hipana* (Uapui), and she stayed there. After *Kuwai* was born, he was hidden from her at a place downriver. At *Dumalipekwa,* three places below. *Thuruapekwa, Thiripidapekwa. Nhiãpirikuli* went after him."



Fig. 6: Amaru Seated At The Sacred Boulders Of Hipana (drawing by T. Aguilar, Uapui, 2010; photo by I. Fontes, Ukuki, 2010). The drawing actually shows Amaru seated at *Tsúwai*, place where "the waters no longer flow", at the edge of the world.

Kuwai is the child of the Creator with the First Woman; he was conceived through a shamanic act in which *Nhiaperikuli* sent his heart-soul into the body of *Amaru. Nhiaperikuli* wanted to have a child through whom all of his knowledge and

soul would be transmitted. The child, however, was an astonishing mix of creative sound and violent pain and destructiveness, who was banished to the 'end' of the world, then still miniature. The powerful and dangerous life-force that *Kuwai* represented may be understood as the 'body of the cosmos', permeated with holes, capable of transforming into multiple spirit-entities, or the forces of nature (the fertility of the forest and rivers, the devastating deluge of the rains, the fearful darkness of night), of initiating new generations of adults, teaching children everything about the world. The dangerous powers of his body were, in the end, harnessed by being transformed into the material shapes of flutes and trumpets, each representing at once a part of *Kuwai'*s body, a first ancestor of a phratry, or a relation of alliance or antagonism that characterized the primordial way of life.

The life-force that *Kuwai* represents includes society-in-time; that is to say, the entire story can also be understood as an explanation for how patrilineal heart-soul, or life-force, came to be embodied in material forms (the sacred flutes and instruments) and reproduced over time and space. As long as there have been "people" in This World, the belief in the *Kuwai* first ancestors has been the foundation for their organization into society.

The women's major role in the process of creation, besides containing this cosmic entity within her body, was precisely to introduce change in the midst of continuity. Shamans state that, after the birth of *Kuwai*, the first woman's blood overflowed the boundaries of the primordial, miniature world around *Hipana*, filling up the pre-existing riverbeds, and making the rivers flow out, thus fertilizing the earth. This event was the second of the most important sources of change and

motion in a new, dynamic, and expansive universe (the first being the felling of the Great Tree of Sustenance). Before this happened, the primordial universe was self-contained in a miniature area around the "Universe Umbilicus", a still-spiritual connection between the first world and the new world that was coming-into-being.

The Women's 'Pilgrimage' with the Sacred Flutes and Trumpets.

Taking the story of *Kuwai* as a whole, there were actually three moments when the women "opened up" the world: after the childbirth, when *Amaru's* blood trickled out of the miniature world and filled the pre-existing streambeds; at the end of the first boys' initiation ritual when the women stole the sacred flutes and trumpets (the transformed body of *Kuwai*, consumed in a great world-fire, at the end of the first initiation rite, that made the world contract to its miniature size) and paraded throughout the world playing them; and finally, after a war in which the men recovered the sacred flutes from the women, he sent four women off to the ends of the earth, while one stayed at the center.

In the second 'opening', the men chased after the women and made omens to warn them of their pursuit. The Hohodene traditions remember a long sequence of five voyages that were made in primordial times by *Amaru* and the first women who had taken the sacred flutes away from the men after *Nhiaperikuli* had partially made them. The women fled from the men and played the instruments throughout the known world. The world then opened up again from its then miniature size to its present-day size, through the power of the music and sounds of the flutes and trumpets (*limalia-iyu*). *Amaru's* father was Tapir, the same who had stolen the

original shamanic powers from *Nhiaperikuli.* It was similarly the shamanic power and knowledge embodied in the instruments that *Amaru* and the women took away from the men, the essence of *Nhiãperikuli's "*heart-soul".

The women went in four directions, expanding along the same riverbeds that *Amaru*'s blood had filled. The map below traces the "voyages of the women with *Kuwai*", beginning at the center (*Hipana*), expanding in four directions outwards to the ends of the known world. The first voyage actually traces a circular shape connecting the two sacred places that have the greatest power in the story of *Kuwai*: *Hipana,* where the child was born; and *Ehnipan*, where he was consumed in a great bonfire. This circle of the center is called "the shield of" (*liwapere*) the primordial shaman/chanter *Dzooli* (hence protection is the main objective of the chants).

On the far upper Uaraná stream (*Dzukuali*) upstream from *Hipana* is a place called *Motipana,* with large stone formations that are said to represent Amaru and the first women's cave/fortress. There, the women performed the first initiation rites for their daughter. There also, *Nhiaperikuli* and his allies, the birds and animals, waged war against the women, took back the flutes, and sent four of the women to the ends of the earth. This sacred place is also said to be the place of the origin of all the waters of the rivers in the region.

The remembrance of these events is performed in the sacred chants at all initiation rites, when every initiate is introduced to knowledge of the spirit world and the laws for living in society. When the sacred initiation chants were transmitted by *Kuwai* in the first ritual of initiation, humanity received the

potential to fertilize the world by shamanizing and neutralizing its dangers. The sacred story and chants in no way annul time, but rather align change and continuity within the temporal and spatial coordinates of the universe.

Exile Or Diaspora ? Ambiguity In The Sacred Journeys

In this third moment, *Nhiaperikuli* dispatched the women to the four directions of the sky, sending them on missions to become the "mothers of the white people" (the Portuguese and Spaniards in Portugal and Spain). The women became the conduits of openness to the external world and its alterity. The flutes which remained with the men, on the other hand, are the "body of *Kuwai*", the continuity of the primordial world for all future generations (*walimanai*). Identity will never be lost as long as power is maintained over its most potent, primordial symbol. Women retained the ambiguous power of reproducing alterity, however, which can have either destructive or creative impacts on humanity. The women are, according to the narrative tradition of *Kuwai,* shamanic intermediaries with the outside world just as male shamans are intermediaries with the Other World of the great spirits. Both therefore are locked in a kind of complementary opposition that is the moving force or dynamic of reciprocity and exchange, implying both marriage and sorcery.

[LOCATION OF MAP OF KUWAI'S 2-5TH VOYAGES

Ancestral power embodied in the flutes and trumpets, known collectively as "*Kuwai*", thus distinguishes one phratry's collective identity from another. Since the law of exogamy (marital exchange) is a centrifugal force through which the external world (in-marrying women, non-indigenous peoples) penetrates the internal world of the sib/phratry, there is an extreme taboo on showing the flutes to the women, which we interpret to be an adaptive mechanism to preserve intact the internal continuity of phratric identity against the threatening powers which outsiders represent.

The "Great City of Ñaperikoli" – where Immortality was Lost.

For the Arawakan-speaking peoples of the far upper Içana River in present-day Colombia, there are mythscapes of major importance. One is called the "Great

City of *Ñaperikoli*" (*Yakale Makakoe* in the Koripako language), a site connected to another known the "Fortress of the Women", both located on the Yawiary stream. Both of these ~~may perhaps be the same sites as~~ are similar to what the Hohodene refer to as *Motípana,* the fortress of the women, a cave where there are stone statues of the primordial women. There are overland and riverine connections between the upper Uaraná and the Yawiary stream, as well as between the far upper Içana and the upper Uaupés Rivers in Colombia.

For the Koripako of this region, however, we cannot say that the "Great City" is of "their" living traditions as a people. Unlike among the Hohodene, very few Koripako elders remember the meanings associated with this Great City, though they do affirm that what they remember comes from their forebears. Another stream further up the Içana was of much greater importance for the Payoaliene sib of the Koripako, as the location of their ancestral villages. While it is true that most of the inhabitants of the region in question are Koripakos who came from the upper Guainia River, there are also numerous descendants of the Cubeo, whose principal territory is further to the west, along the upper Uaupés and its tributaries.

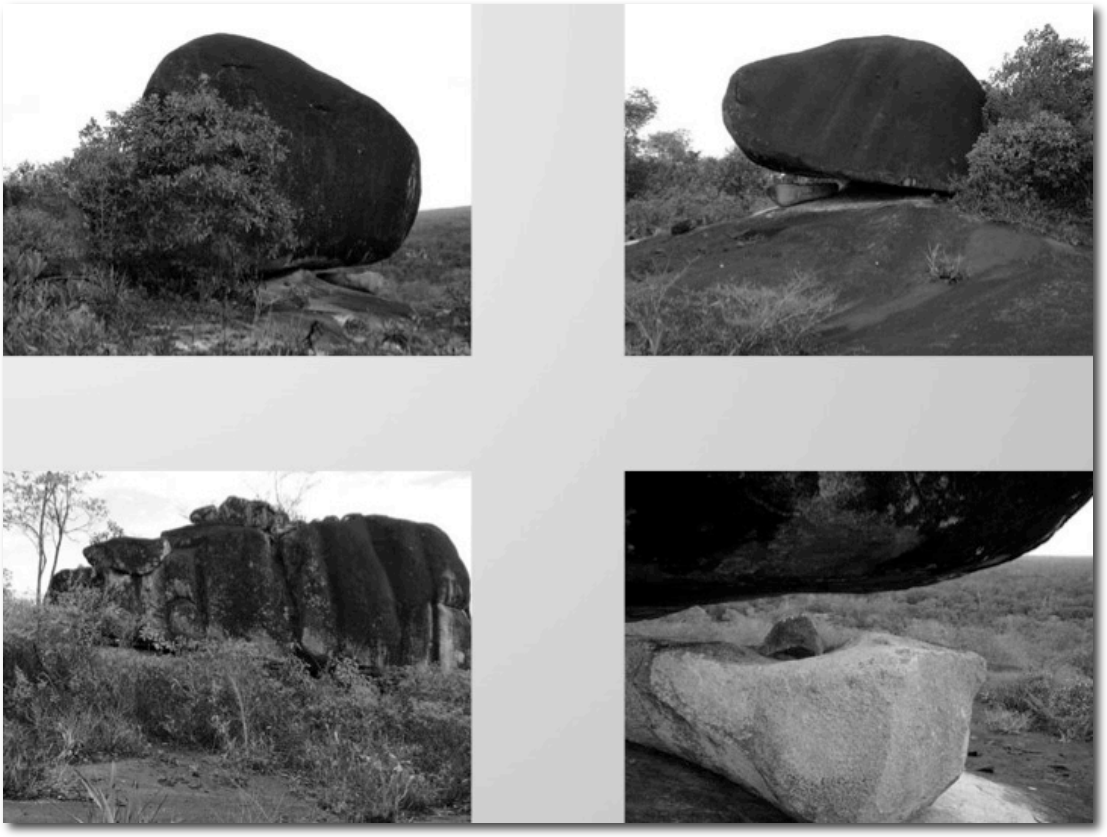


Fig. 8: Four Views of the Great City (photos by C. Xavier Leal, 2013). The Huge Boulder in the upper left is the Main House of *Ñaperikoli* perched on the edge of a granite slope at the top of a hill; the second photo shows a slab of (apparently cut) boulder representing the stone tomb of the "first person to die"; immediately below is a closer shot of the tomb which has a smaller stone ~~piece of~~ at the tomb's head~~, representing the "death mask" of the first person~~; and the fourth photo is the massive stone "kitchen" near the great "House of the Creator".

The cluster of stone formations on the top of a hill at the headwaters of the Yawiary stream off the upper Içana is called "the Great City of *Ñaperikoli*" (Leal's master's dissertation, defended in 2013 at the Museu Nacional in Brazil, presents

the most detailed report on his expedition with Kuripako guides to this site). [8] Nothing similar to it has been reported in the literature on the Koripako or Baniwa (or other northern Arawakan peoples for that matter). It is an arrangement of massive boulders with hardly any petroglyphs on them, yet with an order and meaning attributed to the whole arrangement. The boulders are aligned along an east/west axis. Since *Ñaperikoli* is the sun deity, this alignment is surely significant. Among the multiple meanings attributed to the site, ~~The site as a whole recalls a~~ the principal boulders recall a scene from the story of *Mawerikuli,* younger brother of *Ñaperikoli* and the "first person to die", who was buried underneath the house of *Ñaperikoli,* following the tradition of burials many generations ago. The tradition of *Mawerikuli* is said to be a "Cubeo story", and so it is possible that both Koripako of the upper Içana in Colombia and Guainia, as well as the Cubeo of the upper Uaupés, also in Colombia, may have had settlements in this region.

The "Great City" is an immense rock formation on the banks of the *Yawiari* river tributary of the upper Içana. The hill itself has four access routes: to the north, there is the so-called 'road of *Ñaperikoli',* in the direction of Uapuí, where the Port of *Ñaperikoli* is; to the South, in the direction of the upper Uaupés River and the mouth of the Querari River, where there are hills where the first women, *Amarunai*, lived; the east, the way is closed by forest, but it is said that it is where *Ñaperikoli* placed fishtraps, also in the direction of the headwaters of the Uaupés; finally, the West/southwest, there is the way down the hill. It is estimated that the entire perimeter of the City, four access routes, covers an area of around 15 thousand square meters.

When one reaches the "Great City" by the "road of *Ñaperikoli"*, the first massive boulder is identified as the "House of the Sentinel". Right in front, there is a large stone, surrounded by trees with exposed roots, that at its base, forms a cave with space for one person standing up. It is the "house of *Maadodo*", a primordial bird, a sort of chief and guardian of the city of Ñaperikoli. The house has four openings, the four entrance ways through which *Maadodo* keeps watch over the access routes of the City.

Walking a little more over the black stone ground, there is the stone house of *Ñaperikoli,* a great, oval-shaped boulder, standing proudly over a vast landscape extending as far as the eye can see, in three directions. Immediately behind the stone house, there is another, imposing stone formation, identified as the "kitchen of *Ñaperikoli"* (traditionally, all houses have the main dwelling-place facing the river, and a kitchen construction behind the main house). In contrast with the stone house of *Maadodo*, both the kitchen and the house of *Ñaperikoli* are totally closed. The stone house of *Ñaperikoli* is a black oval monolith, at the base of which is a white stone. On it there is a smaller stone. By hitting the white stone with the smaller stone, a sound like that of a bell echoes throughout the valley. These two stones are called the "bell of *Ñaperikoli'*. Actually, it is still capable of making sound, but, according to the narrators, "in those times, the stone, struck with the force of *Ñaperikoli*, sent out a sound that reverberated throughout the world." The stone house of *Ñaperikoli* is the central point of the Great City, and the Great City is the center of the world. The dominions of the Great City extend to the hills on the horizon in four directions.

A little below, there is the tombstone of *Mawerikuli*, *Ñaperikoli*'s younger brother and the first person to die in the world.[9] It is also a large rock, at the base of which there is another, smaller stone, looking like a person, wrapped in cloth was lying there. This is the "deceased", *Mawerikuli*. An elder narrator told three stories at the base of the stone house of *Ñaperikoli*: the story of the beginning of *Ñaperikoli* and his conflicts with cannibal enemies (the tree-living Thunders, the Jaguar-people), including the episode of the death by poisoning of *Mawerikuli*; the story of *Kuwai* and the stealing of the sacred flutes; and the story of *Kaali* and the beginning of manioc gardens.

The narrator affirmed that the beginning of *Ñaperikoli* was right there, in the Great City. It was he who made the hill, later the stone house and, finally, the tomb for his younger brother *Mawerikuli.* According to the Kuripako narrator, *Ñaperikoli* is a man who is still alive in this world, no-one knows where. "*Ñaperikoli* did not die", he said, "because there is no story about his death."

Like the sacred places of *Hipana* and *Ehnipan*, the Great City indicates an other time, an era prior to 'our' humanity, a smaller and primordial world, in which *Ñaperikoli,* his brothers and their enemies lived under conditions that wre very diferent from ours, today. Above all, however, the mythscape points in a fundamental and unmistakeable way to what all the petroglyphs, stories, and instruments ultimately refer: *Ñaperikoli.*

The Great City is considered a *yarodathi*, a sacred place (like all others discussed in this article). According to narrators, *Ñaperikoli* no longer lives there, but *Maadodo,* the sentinel, does, and the deceased *Mawerikuli* still "exists" there,

laid in his tomb. What makes a place a *yarodathi* is the existence of living beings, guardians, spirits (Hill, 1993; Wright, 1998). And, what makes us know that these entities are there are their actions, narrated by the stories. The stories come, in the beginning, from *Ñaperikoli.*

There are no petroglyphs in the City of *Ñaperikoli* because, according to a Kuripako narrator, "the drawings on the stones came into being from the time of *Kowai* and always due to some act of disobedience." *Mawerikuli* was the first person to die from sorcery because of his thoughtlessness. This occurred in a world marked by violence and conflict with cannibal enemy tribes. That first world is marked by the tomb of *Mawerikuli*, victimized by the ancestral enemies of primordial humanity, which serves as a reminder that it was in that period that death came into the world. "Because of *Mawerikuli,* there is death in the world today. If he had not died, no-one in the world would die, even today." The enemies, according to the Kuripako narrator, knew the promising future of the human generations to come, and wanted to "cut it by the roots. "

The image in the drawing below shows the spirit of *Mawerikuli* rising from his stone tomb; this drawing, made by a shaman's apprentice guided by the descriptions of his living master, has been overlaid on the photo of the stone tomb (photo: C. Xavier Leal, 2013). According to the story, *Mawerikuli* died from sorcery; but it was possible for him to return to life after three days of seclusion in the stone-tomb, and thus all people would continue being immortal, had not an unfortunate incident occurred, the result of which was that he fell back down in the tomb, "nothing but bones". Despite all shamanic attempts to revive *Mawerikuli,*

none of them could bring him back to life. Today, the shamans say that when they are seeking the answer to whether a victim of sorcery will get well or not, they look for the image of *Mawerikuli* to see whether it is rising from its tomb, or it is falling inside. If it is rising, the sick person will return to life; if it is falling inside, the sick person will die. The image of *Mawerikuli* sitting on the edge of his tomb, halfway between life and death, aligned with the position of the sun (which is, in shamanic understanding, the body of the Creator *Nhiaperikuli*) dramatically illustrates the ambiguous situation of the victim of sorcery. Whether the ambiguity is resolved (that is, whether *Mawerikuli* will return to life) will depend entirely on the power of the shamanic cure.

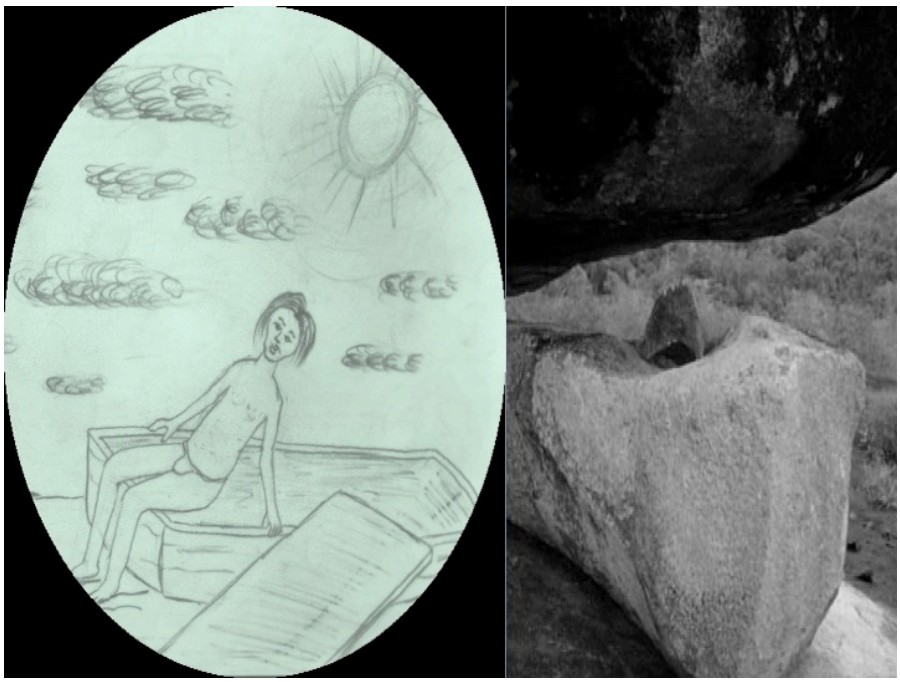


Fig. 9: The Tombstone of Mawerikuli, the first person to die in primordial times. (Image drawn by T. Aguilar, 2010; photo by C. Xavier Leal, 2013)

For shamans of the upper Aiary River, who never converted to evangelicalism, the stone tomb of *Mawerikuli* retains its living meaning; through

their visions, *Mawerikuli* in his tomb serves as a reference for determining whether a victim of sorcery will recover or not.

If there is a correlation, in the cosmovision of the Baniwa, between the sun's path across the sky and the arrangement of the boulders at the site, this would reinforce an association with themes of death and rebirth.[10] Like *Hipana*, the "city" is part of a much larger and more complex site associated with other places, such as the "cavern of the women" where, according to the *Kuwai* story, *Amaru* and the women hid after they had stolen the flutes from the men. This complex site contains a large number of rock formations and caves. Near the “Great City”, there is also a place on the Surubim stream, deep in the forest off the upper Içana, where a large flat rock sits atop a hill overlooking the river and a vast expanse of forest--a place where, it is said, *Ñiaperikoli “*sat and saw how the world would be" (Xavier Leal 2013).

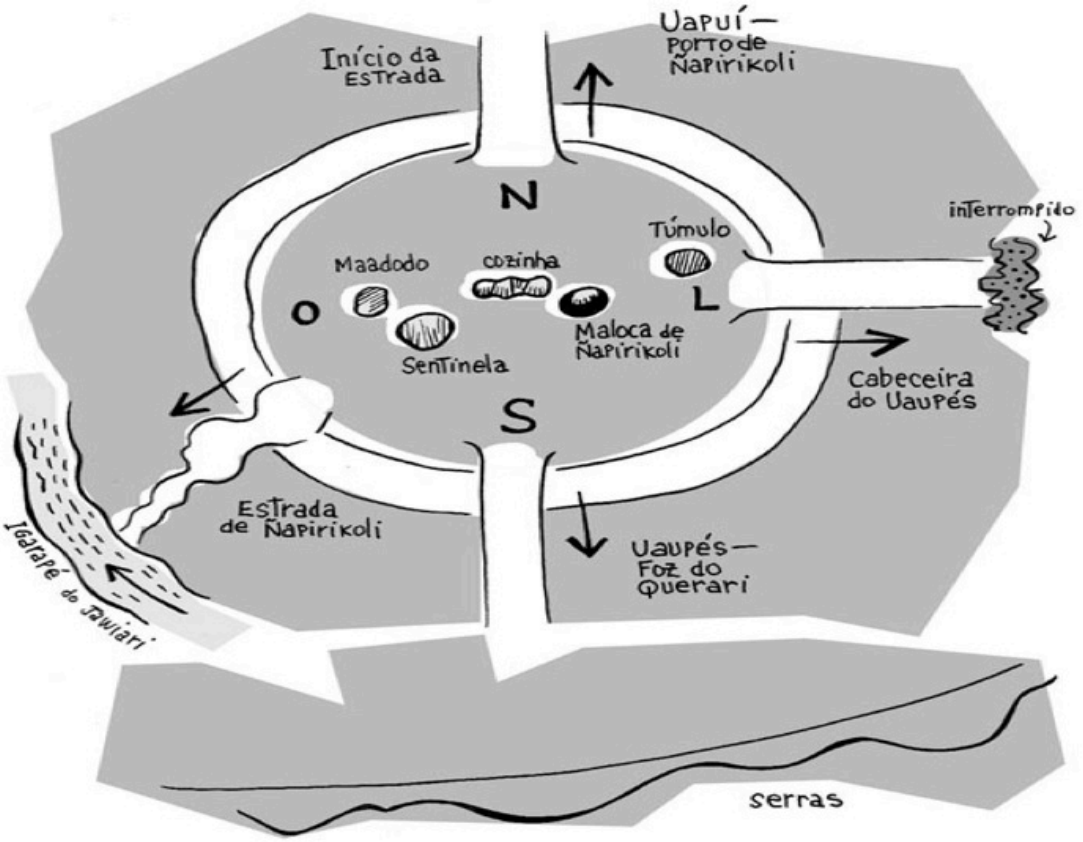


Fig. 10: Croquis of the "Great City" (Xavier Leal, 2013)

In the above **croquis** of the site, it is possible to see that it is oriented in such a way that it leads to several of the main rivers of the region as well as other mythscapes. From its perspective, the site acquires a view from the center looking outward over the vast terrain of rainforest and clusters of hills in the direction of other mythscapes such as at *Hipana*. This perspective would be distinct from a person situated at *Hipana,* the universe center at Uapui, connecting upriver (to *Warukwa* on the *Dzukuali* stream*),* downriver (to *Ehnípan*), up to the sky umbilical cord, or down through the hole of emergence to the world below. According to a Kuripako narrator, "The house of Ñaperikoli is the center of the Great City, and the

Great City is the center of the world", since each clan or phratry established 'its' center of the world. For the Hohodene of the Aiary, the center of the world is Uapuí Falls, *Hipana*, while for narrators of the mid-Içana, the center is the place where the first initiation happened, *Ehnípan.* These perspectives do not contradict each other; they are complementary, and the term 'multi-centric mythscapes' seeks to convey this idea.

Historical Exile And Return

We briefly refer now to stories of the ancestors of a more recent past that tell of their forced exile from ancestral lands at the time of first contacts with the non-indigenous world (Wright, 2005). Undoubtedly corresponding to the periods of indigenous slavery or *descimentos* (relocation downriver to colonial towns) of the 18th Century, the Hohodene and other phratries remember how heroic chiefs fled from the colonies and returned to the phratric homelands, in the heart of their territory. Their return home coincided with a time of warfare and sickness in the colonies. The indigenous peoples had lost much of their ritual dance ornaments and instruments in this exile downriver, and had become extremely reduced in number by the time they fled and returned. Through the intermediation of the women from other phratries, the Hohodene ancestor was able to make alliances, and regain the phratry's social viability. Since then, the phratry has grown and prospered.

These 'historical' traditions are connected directly to ancestors who probably lived in the latter half of the 19th century, beginning of the 20th Century. Today, those ancestors are remembered for their courage in returning to their

homelands and reconstructing their society through marital and political alliance empowering them to resist exile later in their histories.

Still, the relocation downriver created an ambiguity in the Hohodene vision of their society in history that starkly represents the violence of contact: the descendants of the ancestors who sought refuge from the colonial situation claim that there is today a place downriver which is "theirs" by virtue of their exile. Yet, the same descendants associate the downriver world with the transformation of those historical ancestors who remained in the colonies into "white people", "soldiers". The downriver world represents loss of identity, transformation into "others" , the very enemy which forced them into exile, yet there is still an historical claim to a "piece of land" that they consider "theirs".

Spiritual Protection For The Living

Finally, another tradition in the Northwest Amazon consists of the pilgrimages faithful believers make to the tombs of the great shamanic healers, savants, considered as 'saints' and 'saviors' of the past. The Northwest Amazon has had a long history among Tukanoan and Arawak-speaking peoples of such 'wise people', 'dreamers', powerful shamans, and even gifted children who have demonstrated their direct connections to the creator-deities, souls of the deceased, and have initiated 'cross cults' associated with places of ceremonial dance.

In extensive field research along the tributaries of the upper Guainia, Omar González-Ñáñez, and the Baniva elder Hernan Camico documented the burial site

of the most famous of these prophet-seers, Venancio Camico, known popularly as the “Christ of the Içana” (see Wright 1981, 2005; Wright & Hill 1986), who is remembered today in numerous oral traditions of Arawak and non-Arawak-speaking peoples of the region. He was a miraculous healer from the upper Guainia River with a great many followers who came from afar to consult with him and follow his counsel. He was known as a “*talisri*” (dreamer or seer). The oral traditions about Camico state that his principal message was the elimination of sorcery and the installation of a society based on harmonious conviviality.[that is, a reform in the collective heart/soul of the community] He began a tradition called the "Song of the Cross" in which people would dance with or around a Cross; as his fame grew, the local military government heard that he claimed to be a ‘saint’, and had a great following, so they went to test him and take him prisoner. Persecuted by the military from Venezuela, he sought refuge on the Âki River at a site called *Mawáanali.* He first lived at a settlement called *Wayánatsi* («Guayana»), on the caño Âki, but with the spread of his movement, church and government officials began harassing him and his followers. So they fled to *Mawáanal*i. There, indigenous people from the Xié River in Brazil joined up with Camico. He also had a settlement on the *caño Mâni* . Finally, he moved to the village of Macareo (Caño Âki), where he died in 1903. There is a tomb made in the creole style where he was buried; many Baniva from Maroa, and Baniwa from the Aiary River continue their firm belief in Camico to the present day, visiting the tomb and leaving candles there asking for the protection of their well-being.



Fig. 10: Mid-19th Century Savant and Seer, Camico, 'saint' of the Baniwa

(lithograph from the Museu Nacional, UFRJ, Rio de Janeiro)

In a parallel fashion, the Hohodene of the Aiary River who followed the seer/savant Kudui in the 1960s-1970s visit his grave at the cemetery on the island of *Warukwa,* sacred place of the House of *Nhiaperikuli,* for his soul remains by the side of the grave to assist his kin and whoever seeks his protection. It was Kudui who had instructed the Hohodene that the true "center of the Universe" is the **Boulder of *Dzuliferi***, the primordial shaman, slightly above *Hipana* rapids. People today leave offerings at this boulder, asking for the protection and help of the great Spirit of Power, against sickness, or attacks by potential enemies.[11]



Fig. 11: The Boulder of *Dzuliferi* at *Hipana*

(Photo by Isaias Fonte, 2010; with overlay of drawing by Thiago Aguilar, 2010)

There is, finally, a genre of healing chants performed whenever a person has suffered a serious accident that has left him/her unconscious (being hit by a fallen tree, weakness and anemia associated with sorcery). It is explained that, when that happens, the victim's soul has been engulfed by a giant water serpent and taken downriver to the periphery of the world around the first city of the White People (São Gabriel da Cachoeira, in the state of Amazonas, Brazil). The serpent is killed, its body ripped open, and the victim begins a long canoe journey from the peripheral world back to the world-center, a sanctuary or haven from the dramatic effects of epidemic diseases coming from the world of the Whites. Along the way, the soul is nourished by the healing power of honey from the bee-spirits, and the sweet, healing nectar of tree fruits. The journey back to the center coincides with the gradual healing of the person's soul and body, such that, by the time the chanter has finished, the victim should have recovered his/her senses,

and come back into life. In the story to which the healing corresponds, the Creator asks his younger brother, "so, you have exchanged your life for another?" – indicating reversal of death in the peripheral zone by complete revival at the world-center, having passed through the spirit-worlds of the shamanic bees and drunk their remedies.[12]

Warekena Mythscapes and Pilgrimages along the Upper Rio Negro-Guainia and Cassiquiare Basin

According to other versions of northern Arawakan-speaking, Maipurean societies, such as the Warekena, the process of ethnogenesis (or, the beginning of ethnic groups)(González-Ñáñez, 2013) occurred at *Hipana* (Uapui rapids), considered the "World Umbilicus**".** From that site, several peoples initiated their migrations, with *Iñápirrikuli-Ka-Kúwai* as their leader, beginning to expand and populate the world. Many of them crossed rivers, creeks and jungle roads until they settled in places in the Guainía and Orinoco basin. Each time they reached a place, they performed sacred rituals under the leadership of *Iñápirrikuli,* the Creator, and thereafter, he and the "Creator´s people" founded new villages after each ritual of Initiation. (ibid.)

In the times of *Iñápirrikuli´s* world tour (also known as *Kuwai's* sacred voyages), he and his troop camped at Capihuara and they made a ritual feast. They called it ***Kasíjmakasi*** (which is a "rite de passage" or initiation ritual). They

designed or painted many petroglyphs which can be seen today at that ancient place. One of the most sacred beings at Capihuara is ***Siwáli,*** an Arawakan ancestor. For the Warekena people, one of their most sacred places was at Capihuara (***Siwáli***) on the Cassiquiare river, a riverine channel connecting the Orinoco with the Rio Negro river near San Carlos de Rio Negro, Amazonas state, Venezuela.

Part of the myth-history explaining this is as follows:

THE PROCESSION OF THE KÚWE ACCORDING TO THE WAREKENA TRADITION. STORY OF THE INITIATION OF THE DAUGHTER OF GRANDFATHER *SIWÁLI*. (Told by Pedro Francisco Bernabé - Warekena, Capihuara, Cassiquiare - 22 July 1987.) (text transcribed by González-Ñáñez)

At the beginning of ***Kúwe*** (*Kúwai*), who was born on the Aiary River, a branch of the Içana, the Creator of the Arawak commenced the repartition of the ***Kúwe*** for the entire world. They were shared amongst various lands. One part went to Brazil (in the south). The ***Kúwe*** which corresponded to the Warekena [ancestors] took the following way: it descended the Inirida River (Colombia) from the upper Içana and from there the ***Kúwe*** continued on. On the Inírida he reached the rapids of Kubalé (*Kúwaili)*. He formed this great rapids. It is to this rapids that almost all fish go to lay their eggs. This was the work of ***Nápiruli*** who was the same *Kúwai* of the ancestors. He made it so that it would be easier for people to catch fish for the ***Kalíyama*** **(*kalidzamai*** in Hohodene) or ritual food for initiation.

The ***Kúwe*** (that is to say, ***Kúwe*** and his procession) continued on downriver to the Vichada.

One part of the group reached the mouth of the Vichada but another part went to the Guaviare. There they divided and came back together. Some went by the upper Orinoco and others came by the Atabapo River. They passed by the stone slab of jabúa [shining erisma tree] called by the Baniva "*îipane ûusru*". There they gathered a collection of artwork for the initiation of the daughter of ***Átu*** (grandfather) ***Siwáli*** in Capihuara, an ancient comissary of the Cassiquiare. The various groups of ***Kúwe*** passed by each river. One of them arrived at the mouth of the San Miguel or ***Itíni- Wíni*** river.

The other group went down the Atabapo to the ***Témi*** and and soon passed by the port of Yavita (***Aputsá***). There, on the stones can be seen the traces of the ***Kúwe***. Soon after, they passed by a trail through the forest that led them to the banks of the caño ***Pimichin*** (Pamitsîni) . According to Baniva oral tradition, the trail from Yavita to Pimichín was opened in the times of the Creator, ***Nápiruli***. The tracing of this trail was done when two groups of the procession of ***Kúwe*** and ***Nápiruli*** proceeded by going from side to side (several from the ***Pimichín*** **and** others from Yavita) following the "sounds of the sacred animals." This coincidence is important in that it reinforces the Maipure-arawakan tradition and history of the Creation. (for further information see González-Ñáñez, 1968)

There they brought together the ***Kúwe*** that they thought to take to the great festival of Capihuara where the daughter ***Siwáli*** would "partake of the ***Kalíyama***"[the sacred bread, fish, and pepper] One of the groups that had divided

in Yavita continued onward up the Témi and passed over to the ***Simakéni*** (tributary of the Caño San Miguel) by an abandoned trail and came out to a site on the San Miguel that they named "***Sapo***", and which the Warekena call ***Duádua-nawi*.** There on the San Miguel they passed by where there were people fasting in preparation for the festival at Capihuara. There they gathered, at grandfather ***Atu Wichúwi-Chulínawi*** (owner of the whips or *kapési)*. Further up from there, on the same San Miguel, both the group that came from the mouth of this caño, and the peoples which had entered by way of *Simakéni* joined together in a site called ***Madénawi*** where they broke the shells of many of the fruits that they had gathered for that ***Abálesi*** (festival of fruits, or ***Dabokurí)*** which in reality would be a ritual of initiation. All of them went on by San Miguel, they made a journey that descended to the port of the "painted rock", on the Casiquiare where they joined together other paintings or artworks. For their part, the other that came up to the Cassiquiare from the Río Negro passed by the site they called "***Esterita***", on the Cassiquiare, from where they gathered together the artwork that was also for the festival of ***Siwáli***. Finally, they all arrived at the gathering in Capihuara.

Once in Capihuara they went to where ***Depenáwe*** was, who was the chief or lead dancer (*mádzaru*) for the initiation of the daughter of ***Siwáli****. (****Depenáwe*** is also a caño and site that is not very distant from Capihuara.) There, there was a great ceiba tree where they found a pole for hanging the hammock of the girl who was fasting. Above ***Depenáwe,*** there was a caño, on the right bank of the Cassiquiare, called ***Dorotomóni***, situated about four hours walking distance from ***Depenáwe***. There was another point for the young girl's hammock, hanging from

another pole. When they got there – in the early dawn – they passed by the mouth of another caño called ***Koromóni***. They passed by a curve of this caño while the other group followed a curve on the caño ***Beripamóni***. There they stayed through the night until the morning.

For its part, the ***Siwáli*** group was already there in Capihuara. Finally, when the people from above arrived at dawn at Capihuara, ***Depenáwe*** was already there and the young girl had already partaken of the sacred food, ***Kalídama***. There, all the groups that had arrived from all parts came together in the morning and each one partook of the ***Kalídama*** after the initiated girl and stayed the morning in Capihuara drinking, eating, and dancing to the sound of the dance called the "gallinetica" (the dance of the ***Yúwiriru*** for the Warekena).



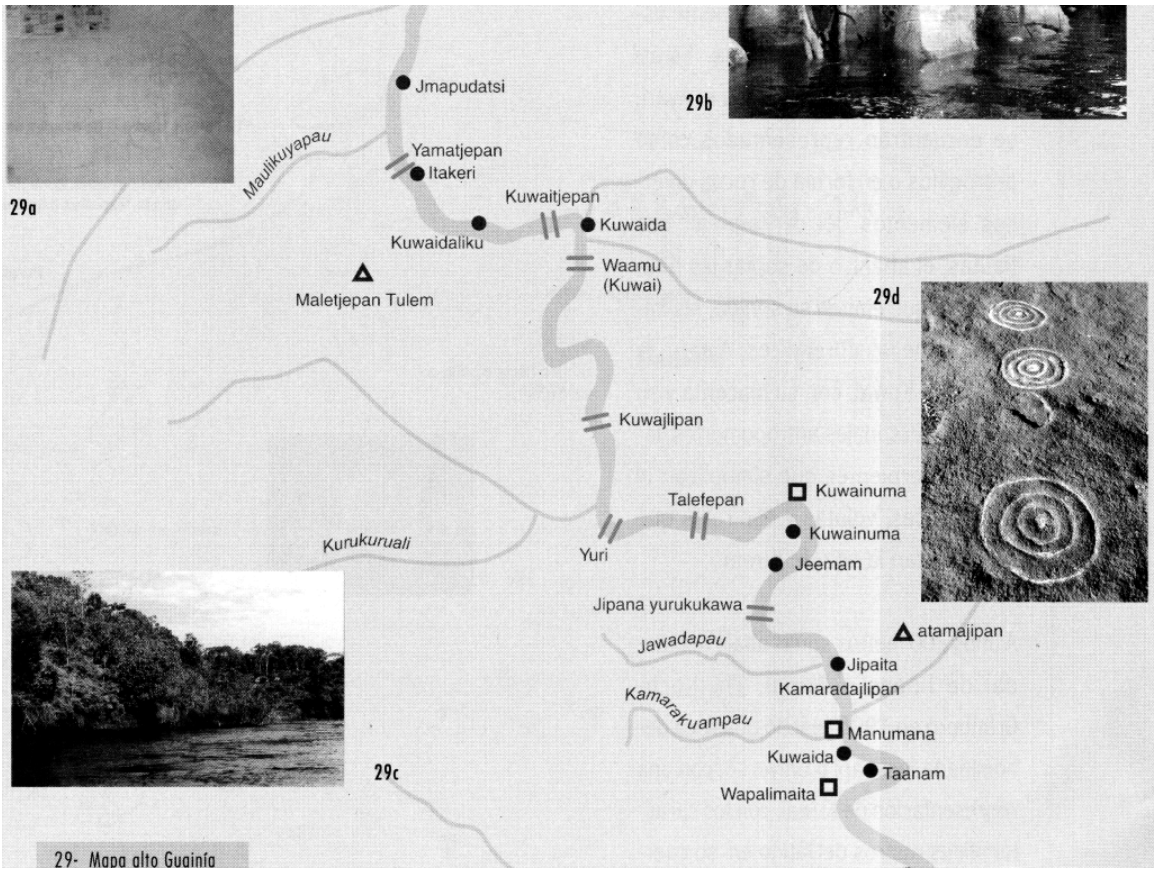








Fig. 12: Petroglyphs at *Siwiali* (Photos: O. González-Ñáñez, 2009)



29- Mapa alto Guainía

Map 3: Partial Map of Mythscape on Upper Guainia with insets of petroglyphs

(from: Ortiz, Francisco (Pacho) y Helena Pradilla. 2002**)**

Along the Arawak mythical territory of the Guainia-Rio Negro we find many other mythscapes. For example, there is one in the San Miguel or Itini Wini stream, a traditional Warekena *caño* which is documented in *Mitología Guarequena* (González-Ñáñez, 1980) but such mythscapes are not as sacred as that of *Siwáli* in the Cassiquiare.

We find sacred places in the upper Guainia, near the town of Victorino, Guainía-Venezuela, today a Kuripako community; very near to Victorino is an island named ***Tuwimirrin*** where there are also important sacred and mythical petroglyphs.

In the Atabapo river basin area, in the city of San Fernando de Atabapo, barrio "La Punta de Lara", there was also an important mythscape possibly from the origins of the Maipurean Tsáse or Piapoko people. Archeologically, they belong to the extinct Nerikawa (Nericagua) people, a Proto-Piapoko sib. According to S. Vidal (1993), La Punta was an ancient Arawakan ceremonial sacred place for the time of the *Kuwai* sacred voyages. Alberta Zucchi (1992), K. Tarble (1985), and J. W. Greer (1995) also studied the "Nericagua complex" and the rock paintings of the Orinoco basin. Tarble further relates petroglyphs to the system of caves, since she interprets co-occurrence (both within caves and within larger geographic areas) as cultural association (Tarble and Scaramelli 1993). The asymmetrical designs, thought to fall into the sacred category above, are said also to occur on

numerous petroglyphs associated with many sites in the middle Orinoco area. It should be noted that Tarble has recorded petroglyphs not only along the river, but also in more upland settings, including inside rock shelters and boulder shelters (also Tarble 1990). She sees these petroglyphs as representative of a ritual mode of Arauquinoid decoration. (In: J. W. Greer, 1995: 205-207)

Conclusions. We have examined in this study several of the 'mythscapes' that northern Arawak-speaking peoples of the Northwest Amazon have constructed and utilize as references to their primordial past, their historical past, and their living present. Such mythscapes are 'multi-centric' – each of which can be understood from its own perspective, or from a collectively held view as elaborated in the sacred stories. The stories of creation connect the centers; the powerful chants that accompany the same stories generate non-linear yet structured movements from the center outwards to the limits of known space-time followed by a return inward to the source of ancestral power. Centrifugal and centripetal movements are enacted in every initiation rite when the music of the instruments makes the world grow, at the same time the chanters create protective shields for the new generations of life. The primordial processions of the flutes and trumpets are like pilgrimages, in that they have sacred centers as their reference points connected amongst themselves and to the 'ends; of the world. This we saw in both the journeys described by the Hohodene chants, and the Warekena sacred story, in which the primordial beings parade with the sacred flutes that leave from the great world-center, disperse in various directions, and

return to a place of gathering, renewal of life, rebirth from the dangers of the peripheral world. The peripheries are the spaces of alterity, associated with spirits of the dead, other tribes who do not speak the same language nor follow the same ways of life as the northern Arawak-speaking peoples. [13]

The processions or returns to the center of the world, the sources of ancestral emergence are necessary to "bring back" the soul from its centrifugal voyages, concentrate it collectively in a protected sanctuary, and re-connect with the life-force that generates all being. In referring to the cosmic significance of these ritual pilgrimages, Sullivan (1988: 317) writes:

> "Understanding the fully sacred meaning of the procession and obtaining this knowledge experientially offer the [initiates and] community the chance for reflexivity and control over the meaning of change. …[T]he community not only grows in the form of future physical life but also regains contact with the sacred foundations of symbolic form itself, the distinguishing mark of human culture…"

In the narratives and, sanctuaries, sacred forms are understood to be spatio-temporal portals to "other" worlds, while in shamanic healing chants, the centrifugal and centripetal movements situate primordial identity constantly in tension with historical alterity.

Ambiguity inheres in these sanctuaries, for they are of both worlds - this material world and the other, spirit world at one and the same time. The sanctuaries were "made" (the petroglyphs inscribed on the boulders; the boulders put into place; the sites brought into being) in the primordial time, while the

events they symbolize took place; consequently, they all have times of their own. Nevertheless, the powers with which they were imbued are still vibrant and present, demanding appropriate respect and caution. Ambiguity resides in the context – when the two worlds mix during the rites and ceremonies, situations that can provoke the elimination of one or the other world until they are separated. Shamans, however, regularly in their cures bring the two worlds together. When they do, they announce that they are bringing the "new, Other World" into This world; which is to say, they exercise their 'world-making' powers (cf. Overing, 1990; Wright, 2014) to renew the primordial spirit-world in the healing of This (corporeal, material) World.

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[1] J. Hill was the first to analyze such movements in function of the ecological alternation between two settlement patterns, but also extending these to the sacred chants sung during the rites of initiation with the sacred flutes and trumpets (1993).

[2] Over the last few years, there has been a notable effort on the part of indigenous organizations and government agencies in Colombia and Brazil to support the revitalization of this cultural heritage through recognition by the UNESCO in the year 2010. There have been numerous projects supported by humanitarian and charitable foundations over the past 20 years that have to do with the revitalization of institutions suppressed by Catholic and Protestant evangelical missionaries during the 20th Century.

[3] There are certainly other mythscapes that could be included in a larger study: besides *Ehnípan*, or Jandú on the mid-Içana River, there are the massive boulder formations with petroglyphs, at Jurupary Cachoeira, *Ínyaipana*, at the headwaters of the Aiary River, near Cubeo settlements today, but which in the past, was inhabited by other peoples called *Liedauiene* (possibly a Baré sib) and *Aialípe,* ancient people of the upper Aiary. Also, Vidal (1987) has conducted extensive work on the historical migrations of the Piapoco (*Tsáse*) from *Hipana* to their present location along the Guaviare River in present-day Colombia.

[4] Similar, in many ways, to the well-known "Dreamtime" of the Australian Aborigines (see, for example, the recent documentary "Islands of Sanctuary" produced and directed by Christopher MacLeod, 2013)

[5] The word in Baniwa and Kuripako for 'drawing, design' – often used in relation to the petroglyphs (as well as body painting, or masks) and to 'writing' is *lidana* (more specifically, *hipada lidana,* stone design). Each petroglyph, however, has a specific name, often refers to a specific spirit-entity or primordial being, and in some cases, has the potential of transforming into a living entity.

[6] An example of inappropriate behavior occurs when a person passes near a site where there are images of the "lightning-spirits" (*perukali*) chiseled into the boulders. If the person, in cooking a meal, allows a pot of boiling water to overflow into fire and the steam produces a hissing sound, the lightning spirits become alive as jaguars and attack the hapless traveller.

[7] At initiation and all rituals when the sacred flutes are played, men and women whip each other, and elders whip the children. Whipping (p*akapetakan*) is done both for the purpose of "making the children grow more quickly" and so that people will know how to resist the pain in this world (for, this world is known as "*kaiwikwe*", the "place of pain").

[8] All communities of the upper Içana River say they are evangelicals, having abandoned the traditions of their ancestors. There were never any conflicts with Catholics, as in other parts of the region, because here the Catholic missions never had any influence. Life organized according to evangelical religion promoted the forgetting of ancient traditions amongst the Koripako, leading to disinterest for the stories, events and characters. Because of that, several elderly Koripako insisted on the importance of preserving and recording the Great City of Ñaperikoli since, for most of the population, the stone hill and other, once sacred places of the region have lost their special status. Even though still feared by a few elders, or seen as superstition by the young people, such places do not have any more connection to mythical characters and events.

The stories narrated about the Great City therefore should be understood as remembrances of the last few elders who recall anything about them and who,

before narrating, prefaced their narrations with clarifications that "these were the beliefs of our ancestors; today, we believe in the Word of God, and we do not believe anymore in the ancient traditions." In other words, these elders and these communities no longer 'live' these stories.

[9] See the narrative of the Hohodene and Walipere-dakenai of the Aiary River in Cornelio et al., 1999).

[10] As, for example, one finds in the more elaborate constructions of Sun and Moon temples aligned with the Avenue of the Dead in Mesoamerica, (cf. Carrasco, 2014)

[11] Since a greater part of the northern Arawak-speaking peoples converted to evangelicalism (beginning in the 1950s), the pre-existing 'cross' cults' were transformed into evangelical churches of 'crentes' (believers) whose predominant symbol of religious power became the de-territorialized New Testament.

[12] Hill has argued (1993) that the descent to the east coincides with soul loss and the return to the center, with healing. The chanting itself is sung through an "art of microtonal rising" (ibid.), in which the slow, gradual rising tones correspond to the soul's return journey upriver and back to the center, and the soul's return to health.

[13] Such as the *Maakunai*, all peoples who do not speak the northern Arawak languages – speakers of Cariban, Makuan, and Tukanoan languages; as well as the non-indigenous peoples such as the Portuguese and Spaniards with whom the Hohodene, Baniva, and Warekena have had the most historical contacts.

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